

AM KISHAN



been approved by the NDA regime. The DMK is livid at the Congress for bowing to BJP's demands and withdrawing not just the controversial affidavit but also the one submitted by the Shipping Ministry. Party chief M. Karunanidhi fuelled the controversy by saying, "Who is this Ram? Which engineering college did he graduate from that he could design such a bridge so many centuries ago?" Meanwhile, with the court putting a three-month freeze on the project, DMK is bent on fighting it out. "The Government will soon approach the Supreme Court and obtain appropriate orders to continue work in this region," says Baalu, contrary to the assurances given by ASG.

BJP now says its opposition is not to the project per se but to its alignment.

FRENZY: The backlash may well be a pointer to the mood of next polls

The alignment in question is the alignment No. 6, approved by the UPA Government's Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs in May 2005. Unlike the other five alignments, this involves a passage through the Ram Sethu. According to Baalu, "All the four BJP shipping ministers during the NDA rule froze the same alignment No. 6." Shatrughan Sinha, shipping minister, in 2003, disagrees. "At no point did the NDA take the Sethu project to the Cabinet," he says.

Baal's contention is that at no point did the NDA regime reject the sixth alignment either, even though this was suggested as early as in October 2002. The National Environmental

POINTS OF DISORDER

■ Subramanian Swamy files a writ petition wanting the Ram Sethu be declared an "ancient monument". ASI drafts an affidavit for the Culture Ministry.

■ On September 6, Soni reads the affidavit. She crosses out three mistakes with a black marker. According to sources, one was a grammatical error, another a factual mistake and the third was something she found "highly objectionable".

■ This was sent back to ASI for corrections and the final affidavit was drafted by ASG. Later Soni claimed that while two of the mistakes had been rectified, the third one was not.

■ On September 13, ASG submits the affidavit to the Supreme Court. Para 20 of the affidavit states that mythological texts cannot be used as historical records to prove the Sethu's origin.

■ The next day ASG tells the court that the Government will "re-examine the matter... including any alternative suggestion". This angers DMK. The court freezes the project for three months.

■ Till September 19, Soni is still waiting to meet the prime minister.

Engineering Research Institute (NEERI) was asked in 1999 to prepare an environmental impact report. In 2002, it proposed the sixth alignment as the best alternative. A year later, when Sinha was questioned by the then DMK MP Professor Sankaralingam about the project, he wrote a letter which spoke of the "fresh alignment through Adam's Bridge east of Pamban island" and talked of monitoring the project. Sinha maintains he was referring to the NEERI report and not the canal project. It was, in fact, the UPA Government that finally gave the Rs 2,427.40-crore Sethu-samudram project the go-ahead.

With BJP on a fresh dose of adrenaline and Congress involved in a slugfest, this could well be the curtain raiser for the next Lok Sabha elections.